

The Ledger

Saelunere, Episode Three

Parvo, in the year 756

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The trouble with running away across Oblong Square is that Oblong Square is not very large.

Lark got perhaps sixty feet. There were people in it, not many, the last of the evening trade: a couple of traders breaking down their trestles, two washer-women coming back with baskets on their hips, a man leaning into the handles of a cart. All of them were going quietly about the end of the day, on the exact stones where a thousand people had watched a man die two nights before. She went through the middle of them with the sound of her own shout still going round the walls behind her.

Then something came past all of it faster than she was going.

She did not see him start and she did not hear him arrive. It was the scarred Aela man, the silent one. He had come out of the tavern door behind the woman in the green coat and crossed the whole square in the time it took Lark to cross a third of it. He hit her once, in the back of the head, in passing, and everything in her stopped at the same moment. Her legs went and she came down hard onto one knee on the cobbles, and stopped there. She did not go the rest of the way down, and she could not get up either. That was the strange part, and afterwards it was the part she remembered: she was kneeling in the middle of Oblong Square

with her eyes working and the traders turning round to look at her, and there was nothing whatever she could do with any of it. Her arms would not come up. Her mouth would not open.

The Aela man stood behind her and unhooked a length of rope from his belt.

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Down the alley at the back of the tavern, three people who had made themselves very quiet indeed heard her shout and could see nothing at all.

Felix was nearest the square end, so Felix went first, and he went too fast. Twenty feet up the alley he put his shoulder through a stack of barrels and they went over behind him with a clatter that carried out into the open. He came round the corner with his hand already raised.

He had a clear view of Lark and the man standing over her, and he had begun the spell that stops a person where he stands, the one that had ended the fight in this square two nights ago. He was halfway through it when the woman in green turned her head and looked straight at him.

She did not move towards him. She did nothing that anybody watching would have called a defence. She simply looked, from thirty feet away, at the shape he was drawing on the air, and unmade it.¹ Felix felt it go. There was no light and no sound and nothing at all to show for it. The thing he had been holding simply was not there any more, and the man with the rope went on doing what he was doing.

Behind him Calder came out of the alley at a walk, drawing a sheath of hardened air over his skin as he came,² and looked at the square and understood in about a second that the four of them could not win a fight here.

So he did not start one. He filled his lungs instead and shouted, at the traders and the washerwomen and the man with the cart and anyone else in earshot, that these people were beating up an innocent person and somebody help.

It did not bring anybody running. What it did was slower and better than that. The woman with the laundry basket stopped walking. The man let go of his cart handles. One by one the people at the edges of Oblong Square turned round and stood and watched, and a square full of people watching you is a worse thing to stand in the middle of than a square full of people running at you.

¹**Counterspell.** A spell aimed not at a person but at another spell, in the half second while it is being cast. It requires that you can see the casting and that you are faster than the caster.

²**Mage Armor.** A layer of thickened air held a finger's width off the body, which turns a blow about as well as plate and weighs nothing at all.

Calder was looking at the woman in green when it happened, and he saw it land on her. It was not much. It was a hitch, half a second long, while she looked at how many faces were now pointing her way and did the arithmetic and did not like the answer. Whatever those two were, they had not come here to do this in front of an audience.

The man with the rope did not react to it at all. Calder looked at his face for as long as he dared and found nothing there to work with: no caution, no anger, not even interest.

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The Aela man put the rope round her neck from behind and pulled, and it bit.

Lark's vision went to white and came back and went again. She could feel him settling his weight to start dragging her backwards across the cobbles, and she could feel that he was in no particular hurry about it, and underneath everything else was the perfectly clear understanding that he did not care whether she was alive at the other end of the drag.

She got one hand up under the rope and dragged some air past it, and with the air came her voice.

"Are you going to kill me just for a name?"

He looked straight into her eyes and said nothing. She held on to his face while her sight was going, trying to find one single thing in it she could use, and there was nothing there to find. Not cruelty. Not enjoyment. A man at work, an hour before the end of the shift.

So she stopped asking. She pushed a little warmth into herself, enough to think with. Then she went low. She drove her shoulder across the front of his knees and twisted, and came up and out from under the loop, and the rope came off over her head.

She ran. The Aela man got one hit in on her as she went past him, and she kept running.

"We can run now." Felix, at the alley mouth, with both hands up and his voice pitched to carry. "Lark, come here."

She did not hear it the first time.

"Lark. Come here."

She turned her head and saw him and changed direction, and while she was turning Felix started the same spell again. This time the woman in green was looking the wrong way, and nobody unmade it, and it landed on the Aela man as

he took his first step after Lark. He did not take a second. He froze in the middle of the step, one foot off the ground and his weight going forward, held exactly where he stood.³ In the last of the second before it took him his eyes came round and found Felix, and stayed on him.

And then somebody in the alley started playing.

It came out over the top of the square and it was completely wrong for what was happening in it, slow and warm and unhurried, and the woman in the green coat had been running forward to back up her partner when it reached her. She stopped. She looked up and around for where it was coming from and did not find it. Then she stood in the open, thirty feet from the fight she had started, and listened to it with her face gone loose,⁴ and everybody else in Oblong Square heard one chord come out of an alleyway and nothing more.

Billiam came out of the tavern's front door at a dead run and into the middle of all of it, having spent the last several minutes going from the back room to the bar to the back room again and discovering, each time, that his friends had left without him. He got the shape of it in one look: Lark running, one stranger frozen with his arm out, the other standing in the open with her head tipped as though somebody had called her name from a long way off.

He ran past the woman close enough to touch her and did not touch her, because she was not the problem. He ran past the man with the rope, who could not turn his head to watch him do it, and as he went by he spat in his face.

Then he kept going, out of the square and into the alley after the rest of them, and behind him the man stood with a blob of spit running down his cheek and his eyes still locked on the place where Felix had been.

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They ran for a couple of minutes at everything they had, and nobody came round any corner behind them.

Lark led, because it was her city down here. She took them off the square and up and inward, into the parts of the Stacks where the alleys close over your head and the stairs are somebody's roof, and the further in she got the more the ground

³**Hold Person.** A spell laid over a person's whole body, which stops it. They stay upright and awake and entirely aware of everything, and cannot move any part of themselves, until the caster's hold on it slips.

⁴**Radiant Chorus.** A bard's spell, played rather than spoken. Anyone the player chooses who can hear it either shakes it off or stops where they are and stands listening to it, for as long as it holds.

under her started telling her where she was. Nobody followed. They came out of it onto a landing somewhere with a view and stood getting their breath back.

She found Aeska in the middle of it and got it all out in one piece, still breathing hard, before anybody could ask her anything.

"I'm so sorry, Mr Aeska. I went to talk to the old man and those people came in and they just didn't take no for an answer, they were looking for someone who knows Theo." Her hands had come up and knotted together under her chin. "I swear I didn't give out any names. I didn't mention you. I didn't mention Felix. I just tried to get away. I'm so sorry."

"We got out safe."

"But I think they'll bother the old man now. In the tavern. Because he was the only one with me."

Nobody had a good answer to that, and Aeska did not pretend to have one. He said that unfortunately the old man was not really their problem any more, that what they had to do was stay safe and make certain this did not happen again.

"How do we do that, when they just come up to us like that?" Billiam had his hands on his knees. "We didn't do anything wrong. We were just in a tavern."

"It's what they do, and we don't know much about this group at the moment." Aeska straightened up. "I don't recognise the clothes they're wearing. Do any of you?"

"I think they had the Porter's Guild badge," Calder said. "The woman, at least."

Lark had been closer than anybody, close enough to have been lifted off the ground by the front of that coat, and she had used the time. She told them what the woman had been wearing and what was pinned to it, and that it had not been a crew pin.

Aeska knew the Porter's Guild the way he knew all of them, from an education that had assumed he would one day be running something. He knew that they moved goods, that they were enormous, that everybody in Parvo needs things carried from one place to another and so the Porters have a hand in every part of the city there is. He knew about the crews. And he knew, because it was the sort of thing that had been drummed into him, exactly what it meant that two people had walked into a public house on Oblong Square wearing the guild's own pin and not the pin of any crew under it.

Not a crew, then. Somebody above the crews.

"Brassline is a Porter's Guild crew," Lark said, into the pause. "That's who I worked for. That's who I quit yesterday."

She said it flatly and did not appear to draw anything from it, and left it lying there for somebody else to pick up.

"When I was asking around a couple of days ago," Calder said slowly, "people

were talking about all sorts of guilds. But they were careful about the Porter's Guild. It sounded almost mysterious, the way they went round it. And now these two walk in." He looked out over the roofs. "I really wonder what's going on inside that guild."

Nobody had an answer to that either. It was getting dark, and they were standing on a stranger's landing four flights above the street with another man's blood dried on somebody's sleeve, and none of them had anywhere in particular to go.

"Guys." Billiam said it before he had finished deciding to. "I know a safe spot. Follow me."

* * *

Getting to Billiam's house is ten minutes of ladders and ramps and long shared balconies, and the higher you go the better the view gets, until you come out somewhere near the top of it all with half of Parvo laid out below you going orange in the last of the light. The houses up there were put up as temporary things a long time ago and have been permanent for most of a century. They are built hard against the flank of the great chimney, flush to the brick, because the brick is warm and stays warm all night, and that is the entire reason anybody lives that high.

The doors have numbers on them and no names.

"Right." Billiam had his key out and was not entirely sure, having got them all the way here, what he had brought them for. "We'll be safe here for a bit."

He went in first and called into the room ahead of him.

"Mom, are you home?"

She was at the little kitchen end of the main room with her back to them, doing the washing up after a dinner she had eaten on her own, and she turned round at his voice with her hands still wet.

"Oh, Billy. Billy, I didn't expect you home so soon. I thought you were out cavorting with your friends at the inn."

"We were, yes." He was holding the door. "Guys, just get in. Get in and shut the door."

Four people came into the room after him, and Annie Buckman looked at all of them and was delighted.

"Oh, Billy, these must be your friends." She came across the room drying her hands. "Pleasure to meet you all. You have to introduce me, Billy. It's great to meet some of your friends."

She got about half a sentence into it before she registered the shape of what she had in her front room. Two people her son's age, which was one thing. Then Felix, the better part of ten years older and dressed like a man who works in a spire. Then Aeska, who is not much easier to place. It did not slow her down.

Felix put his hand out first. "Hello. I'm Felix."

"Felix. Oh, pleasure to meet you. Pleasure to meet you." And then, over his shoulder: "Billy, you're being rude. Introduce us."

"This is Felix." He pointed. "That's Calder."

"Hello, Billy's mum," said Calder.

"The not-so-good-looking guy." A pause while he tried to remember. "Aeska, right. And the girl over there in the corner, that's Lark."

Lark bent to ninety degrees. "Hello, ma'am. I'm so sorry to disturb you."

"No, no, no. Not at all. Not at all." She was already going for the kettle. "Come in, come in, I'll make teas for you all. It's a pleasure. It's nice that Billy has some friends coming round the house for a change, you know. Excellent to meet you. Excellent."

She shook all four of their hands, one at a time, and got the kettle on, and then stopped with her hand on the shelf.

"It's an odd time to bring guests home, Billy. Are you -"

"Mom." He had been building up to it for about ten seconds. "Could you leave us for a bit? We've got some stuff to talk about. It's kind of, you wouldn't be interested in any of it."

Annie Buckman looked at her son for a moment, and decided not to ask.

"Of course, Billy. Of course." She was untying the apron before she had finished the sentence. "You and your friends have a nice little meeting. I'll go and water the plants out the back. Don't you worry. The tea will be ready soon, you can pour it."

She went out through the back door, and everybody in the room let their shoulders down about an inch, and then the door opened again.

"Oh, sorry, Billy. I just forgot the watering can. Sorry. Sorry."

She got it and went out again.

"Billy." Lark had not moved from where she had put herself, which was against the wall, taking up as little of the room as a person can. "Your mum's really nice."

"Yeah. Yeah, she is."

"It's a very beautiful building," said Calder.

"It's just anything, right? Lots of people have the same house here." He said it fast and moved on. "Anyway. I figured we could use a spot to lie low."

Aeska had been standing at the back of the room since they came in and had not sat down and had not touched anything.

“Before that, Billy, I do have a thing.” He said it pleasantly enough. “Why the sudden change of heart? You were very secretive with me before about sharing anything. And now all at once you are willing to tell us where you live, and even shelter us. Don’t get me wrong. I appreciate it. It is simply a sudden change.”

“Yeah, but I mean, look.” Billiam turned a cup round on the table without picking it up. “I didn’t know who to trust at first. But now that I feel we’re in danger, I feel like I should keep us somewhat safe. I’m not saying I fully trust everyone. I guess I just don’t really have any better ideas about what to do.”

Aeska took that, and appeared to decide something about it, and then gave something back, which was not a thing he had done much of so far.

“I cannot tell you a lot about this either. Let us just say that for the past two years I have mostly been hiding, working my way round taverns, so I don’t know anything about the politics of that world any more.” He turned his hand over. “However. A good friend of mine, who was very good to me, is now dead. I used to think I should be the one to look into that on my own. But seeing as we have been through quite a bit together, and none of you has tried to kill me yet.” A beat. “I suppose apologies are in order, for my trying to cast a spell on you. Billy. Sorry.”

“That’s fine.”

It was a small apology and a smaller acceptance, and neither of them looked at the other while it was happening.

“Look, I’ll be honest,” Billiam said. “I didn’t really want to meet back up with you lot, because I didn’t want to get into any more trouble than we needed to. But I feel like trouble’s coming to us anyway. So I don’t really have a choice but to figure out what’s going on.” And then, because it had been sitting in him since the yard: “It’s not just this. The people who’ve been leaning on Shrapnel at the scrapyard, taxing him extra. That’s the Corewright’s Association.”

Aeska’s head came round.

The Corewrights are a small guild and a specialised one: essence cores, the making of them and the putting of them into things, and nothing else. They are not the Guild of Engineers, and they are not under it, and in practice they do more or less what the Guild of Engineers tells them.

“How much is a core worth?” Aeska said.

“Depends. Twenty ducats. Thirty, if it’s clean.” Billiam said it without having to think. It is the first question he asks of anything that comes into that yard. “Sometimes more. If you’ve got ten of them in a box, that’s more than a year’s wage sitting on a bench.”

“And when I was at the guild, they ran experiments on wiring a great many of them together. Trying to get more out of fewer, and trying to see what happens if you use a great many at once.” Aeska looked at Calder. “Your old man in the side

house. What did he say the weapon would need?"

"A lot of power." Calder had already got there. "He said a great deal of energy, kept fast and straight over the distance, and that it would be expensive, and that it would not happen in somebody's basement."

"A lot of power means a lot of cores. A lot of cores means money and access."

That went round the room and nobody said anything for a moment, and it was somewhere in that quiet that Lark stopped listening, because none of it meant anything to her and because there was a door at the back of the room with somebody on the other side of it.

She started drifting. Aeska did not notice, because this was the one subject in the world that could take his whole attention, and Calder did not notice for the same reason. Billiam noticed.

"Lark. Do you need some fresh air or something?"

"Oh. Yeah. I just want to take a look at the yard."

"I don't really have a yard." He said it evenly. "But I could show you round later, if you want."

She went out anyway, and he let her.

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It is not a yard. It is a gap.

The back of the house stands hard against the chimney wall with about four feet between them, roofed over at one end by an arch of brick, and in that four feet Annie Buckman has put window boxes along both sides and grown as much as will physically fit in them. Lark came out into it and stopped, because she had not expected any of this to be here.

"Oh." Annie turned with the can in her hand. "Are you alright there?"

"Apologies. I just wanted to take a look." She came a step closer, and then another, and bent down over the nearest box. "Do you really have plants here?"

"Well, the good thing about being up this high, you know, is that we get a lot of sunlight, and we try and make the most of it." She was pleased to be asked. "As you can see, I've got some renna beans coming along here, and some coriander."

Lark went along the boxes looking at every single one of them properly.

"Where are you from, then?"

"Oh, around the Stacks, mostly. But not around here." A pause. "A bit lower down. Towards the ground."

"A lot of lovely places down there in the Stacks, you know. I was born and

raised here myself, so I love the Stacks, high or low. The people here are great." She moved along to the next box. "How did you meet Billy?"

"Oh. Well. We were sort of at the same event. That's where I met him."

"Right."

"So you're Billy's mum." Lark straightened up. "Does he have a dad as well?"

"Yes, his father works at the College. He's a professor there." She kept watering while she said it. "He works late, and he has a lot of very important projects that he deals with, so he's not always around at home as much as we'd like. Of course. But he's got a lot going on. To be expected."

She said it the way you say a thing you have said many times, in the order you have worked out is easiest to get through, and Lark stood in a four-foot gap between a house and a chimney and heard exactly how much it cost her to keep it that light.

"Well. I hope he gets some time off and gets to be home soon." She looked at the beans rather than at her. "I hope. But your house is really nice."

"Thank you. Thank you." And then Annie put the can down. "Our family was one of the first to move into the Stacks, you know. So this family house has been here a long time, and we're very proud of it, and very happy to be part of this community. It's great here, even if some of the people in the rest of the city maybe don't appreciate it as much." She looked out at the brick. "I'd never move anywhere else. Even if I could."

Lark, who had put everything she owned into a sheet that afternoon and carried it across the city on her back, nodded and did not say anything at all.

"I don't want to disturb you any more. Thank you so much for letting us come in."

"Of course. Of course." She was already picking the can back up. "Help yourself to anything in the kitchen, by the way. I think the kettle should be done. Billy's not so great a host, you know, he doesn't get guests very often, so we wouldn't want you missing out on anything. We brew some of our own mint here for the mint tea. You've got to try that. So please. Please."

"Thank you." She had a hand on the door before she turned round. "What was your name again, ma'am? Sorry."

"Annie."

"Thank you, Annie."

"Yes, of course. Pleasure. What was it, Lark?"

"Yes."

"Pleasure."

She went back inside, shyly, the way she does everything, and did not tell anybody in that room what she had just heard, because there was nothing in it

that any of them needed and it was not hers to hand about.

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Inside, they had got as far as Theo's house.

Aeska had gone in on the morning after the killing, and Felix in the afternoon of the day after that, and neither of them had found anything. It was only now, standing in somebody's front room with the tea going cold, that they put the two visits side by side.

"It was already rummaged when I went in," Aeska said. "And I went pretty early in the morning. So it must have been done during the night." He held up a finger. "But here is the thing that has been bothering me. It was locked when I got there. I had to break it. And the door had not been broken before I broke it."

"So whoever went through it had a key," Felix said.

"And locked up again after."

"Or somebody very good with a lock," Lark said, from the wall.

"To lock it again as well?" Felix said, and let it sit.

Somebody had gone into that house on the night Theo died, taken what he kept there, put everything else on the floor, and then stopped on the way out and turned the key behind them.

"Mr Aeska. Mr Felix." Lark had her hands in front of her again. "You two are the people I know were close to Theo. And those Porter's Guild ones were looking for someone exactly like that." She was working up to the part she was worried about. "I worry for you, Mr Felix. You were right next to him for a year. Your face is very known to people who knew Theo. So you might be in the greatest danger of any of us."

"Luckily," Felix said, "I don't have a house any more. So it's a bit harder to find me."

There was a short pause while the room caught up with that.

"You don't have a home?" Lark said.

"Where are you going to sleep?" said Calder.

"I don't know yet."

He had until the end of the day to clear the tenement out, and it was already past eight, and the guild would put whatever was still in there onto the landing in the morning and think nothing of it. He turned it over for about as long as it deserved. It was not much stuff. But going back to the Core tonight meant standing in a doorway he had been thrown out of, with his face and his name,

while two Porter's Guild agents went about the city looking for people who had been close to Theo. That was an expensive way to buy a second coat.

"I'll let them throw it out," he said. "I'll get new clothes."

Billiam had already gone out the back door.

His mother was at the window boxes with the can still in her hand.

"Billy. Have you served the tea to the guests?"

"I will do that soon." He got the door shut behind him. "I actually have a question. Some of these people are homeless, and I was wondering if. Um. If they could stay over just for tonight. If that could be a thing."

"Oh, like a sleepover."

"I -"

"Oh, yeah. Yeah, yeah, of course. I must say, they look very respectable." She was already working out where to put them. "And I know you've said no girls over. But it's never been a problem before, Billy, has it?"

"No. That's true." And then, because it was true and he did not think to keep it to himself: "I haven't really ever had a sleepover. So it's quite exciting."

"Yes. No, I think it's great that you've made some friends."

Lark, who had been listening at the door for all of this, was three feet away and moving fast in the other direction by the time it opened, and everybody in the room watched her do it.

"So," Billiam said. "Who needed a place to stay, actually?"

"Me," said Felix.

"I would prefer to stay here as well, yes." Aeska did not sit down even then. "As I said. It would not be wise to go back to the Plumb and Bob today, after what has just happened there."

Calder had the College. Lark said she had a place, and left it there, and nobody pushed her about it.

The tea got poured. Billiam poured it, because he had been told to.

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They were still working out where to meet tomorrow when Felix stopped in the middle of what he was saying and looked at nothing.

It was Harriet Spurnhold's voice, and it was in his head, and it was going too fast.

Felix. This is really important. The Bellows. Subterminal 8T. Find it. Meet me there at midnight.

And then it stopped, in the way a person stops when they have run out of the room they had rather than the words.

He told them what he had heard, and got about four seconds of respectful silence for it.

“Who is that?” said Calder.

“Is it your wife?” said Lark.

“I don’t have a wife.”

“Oh.” She thought about it. “You don’t have a wife?”

“Girlfriend, maybe?” said Calder.

“No.”

“Boyfriend?”

“The secretary,” Felix said, to the room in general. “The Chief Secretary. She was dismissed the same morning I was.”

Aeska knew the name, and knew the post that went with it, and knew nothing else about her at all. He said that Harriet had sent a message to Felix and not to anybody else, and that she had done it for a reason, and that he did not think it would be wise for him to put his face in front of her tonight.

Which left the difficulty that Felix, who had been sent for, had never been down into the Bellows in his life and had no idea what a subterminal was.

“I know where that is,” Lark said. “Roughly. I know how to get to a place with that sort of name.”

“So do I.” Calder had stood up. “Do you want more company? I’m somewhat familiar with the place.”

“Don’t you have a family waiting for you at home?”

“No. I live at the College.” He shrugged. “I’m in the dorm most nights anyway.”

So it was the three of them, and Billiam and Aeska staying at the house, and about three hours until midnight, which is not very long when you have to get all the way down the Stacks and then find one particular room under the city.

Aeska stopped them at the door.

“I hope she can tell you more about what is going on. We are very much in the dark at the moment.” He caught each of them by the shoulder as they went past, and put a little of what he had into all three of them, a phrase of something under the words that stayed with them afterwards.⁵ “So. Take this.”

Then they went down the ladders and away, and the door shut behind them, and there were three people left in the house.

⁵**Bardic inspiration.** Not a spell, and no bard will let you call it one. A word said into somebody’s ear, a phrase of music, sometimes only a look; and for a while afterwards the person who took it finds there is more in reserve than they had counted on.



You get into the Bellows by going down, and you keep going down longer than you expect to.

The first part of it is residential and does not feel like a tunnel at all. The passages are narrow and warm and lined with doors, one every few feet, put in wherever somebody found a wall they could cut a room out of, and there are curtains over some of them and numbers chalked on others and washing strung across the ceiling in the wider stretches. People sleep down here in their thousands. Lark took them through it at a walk, with her head slightly turned the whole way.

“It’s late,” she said. “Let’s try to be quiet.”

“Agreed.” Calder had been watching her navigate for ten minutes and had a question about it. “How are you so familiar with this place, Lark? It doesn’t seem like you’d be down here much.”

“Really?” She sounded genuinely puzzled by the question. “I mean, I’ve lived here plenty.”

“Ah. Okay.”

“So that’s how.”

She kept her head half turned the whole way, listening, which is why she was in front. She did not bother telling the other two that this was the safe part. The Below Boys do not work the tunnels where people actually live, because robbing a man twenty feet from his own front door makes an enemy of everybody in the corridor, and there is nothing in it for them.

Then the doors ran out.

Past the residential runs the tunnels get bigger and colder and emptier, and are not places anybody lives so much as places you have to go through to get somewhere else. A terminal, down here, is a round chamber where a lot of tunnels meet, more than four and sometimes a great many more. A subterminal is another of the same, further along one particular tunnel. Neither of them had been to 8T, but both of them knew how the numbering ran, and they followed it down.

Subterminal 8T is a circular chamber with eight tunnels running off it in pairs and a single steam outlet standing in the middle. The steam goes up out of it in a column and away through grates that surface somewhere at street level, in a city that never thinks about where its steam comes from. The room is full of it. It hangs in the air and curls along the walls and rolls out into the mouths of the tunnels.

Lark came to the edge of it first and stopped, in the dark of the tunnel, where you can see out and not be seen.

There was one person standing on the far side of the room.

She put a hand back and stopped the other two coming past her.

“Wait. There’s someone there.” And then, quietly: “Felix. Do you see the silhouette? Does it look familiar?”

He looked for a while through the steam. Medium height. A woman, probably. Standing badly.

“It looks like her.”

“Okay.” Lark was already thinking about angles. “Me and Calder should stay here. We’ll watch over you.” She turned to Calder. “I’ll get a bit of higher ground if I can.”

She went up onto a crate against the wall where she could see the whole room and most of the tunnel mouths, and Calder stayed at the edge, and Felix walked out into the open on his own.

* * *

At Billiam’s house, his mother was working out where five people were going to sleep in three rooms, and had got as far as deciding that it would be fine.

“Billy, what happened to the rest of your friends?”

“Um. Yeah. So, well, I guess they had something.” He did not have the second half of that sentence and went and found a different one instead. “But at least Aeska’s here. Did you know he’s a musician?”

Across the room, Aeska looked at him.

“Oh, really? A musician?”

“Yeah. A really good one.”

“Oh, wow.” She turned round properly. “Would I have heard you play anywhere? Are you famous, Mr Aeska?”

“I play in a couple of pubs and bars.” He was very polite about it. “I would not call myself famous. I try to earn a living playing in different bars, really. Perhaps if you had visited one of them, you might have seen me.”

“Oh, no, I don’t really get out to the pubs that much, you know. Shift work. I’m back and forward, don’t have too many free evenings to go and hang out at pubs and things like that.” She put a hand on the back of Billiam’s head as she went past him, and left it there a second. “Maybe in my early years. Not these days. Billy needs looking after.”

“Mom.”

“Well.” She sat down. “I mean. Would you play something for us, perhaps?”

Aeska held Billiam's eye for slightly longer than was comfortable for either of them, and then took the instrument off his back.

"Yes. Of course." He was already tuning it. "It's the least I can do, for you helping us."

He played something slow, and did not do anything clever with it, and did not perform it at them. It is the one thing in his life he does not have to think about, and a small warm room high on the side of a chimney is a better place to do it than a full tavern on a festival night. Annie Buckman sat with her hands in her lap and listened to the whole of it.

* * *

Felix came out of the steam and Harriet Spurnhold nearly went for the tunnel before she saw who it was.

She was in the same clothes she had been wearing in the corridor two days ago, when she had been standing between a locked door and a dozen people who wanted it open, and she had not slept in them. The pen was still through the bun. She was looking left and looking right and shifting from foot to foot, and she had both arms wrapped round a ledger and held against her chest.

"Felix. Felix." She got a hand out and beckoned him the last of the way in. "I'm sorry about the intrusion. I try not to use sending on anybody who isn't expecting it, but this really was an emergency. It's been crazy since Theo was killed." She stopped, and made herself stand still, and looked at him. "Look. How much do you know about Theo's dealings outside the guild?"

"I don't know much about it."

"Oh." Something went out of her. "I sort of assumed. I suppose I assumed that he might have."

She got hold of herself and started again in a different place.

"Well. You know he had a few other, let's say, side projects. Directly after his death, when the rest of the guild came to inspect his office, I locked it." She said it quite steadily. "In order to delay their search. That was me. That was me that locked it."

Felix stood in a steam vent chamber a hundred feet under Parvo and thought about a small precise woman holding a corridor full of guardsmen with nothing but procedure, and understood for the first time that she had not been flustered. She had been buying hours.

"And I went straight to his house. That night. The night he was killed." She

shifted the ledger in her arms. "To fetch this. He gave me a key a long time ago. I don't think he even remembered I still had it." A pause. "I made somewhat of a mess of the place, I'm afraid. But it was important to him that this was kept secret."

And she held it out, and Felix took it.

"The important thing in here is that this is a log of some of the, how do we put this." She was choosing her words even now, even here. "Requisitioned materials from the guild. That are being redirected out of their correct allocations, into some more useful locations. By Theo." She let that stand. "And I've been helping him make sure the books reflected it."

He opened it. It is a ledger like any other ledger, ruled columns and a date at the top of each page, and every line of it is a label and a figure, and the labels are technical and some of them are not in a language Felix can read at all. He knew immediately and with total certainty that he was holding something extremely dangerous and had no idea whatsoever what it said.

"I'm fairly sure the guild knew I was dealing with Theo. That's why they fired me." She was watching the tunnel mouths again while she talked. "And because they fired you, I assumed perhaps you were also involved, and that he simply hadn't mentioned it to me. They certainly may think you're involved with this sort of thing." She looked back at him. "But I think I managed to keep it all out of their hands. The really important thing -"

* * *

At the house, in the middle of the tune, there was a jingling of keys in the front door.

Billiam looked at his mother, and his mother looked at the door, and the door opened, and his father came through it.

Benjamin Buckman stopped one step inside his own home and looked at his son, and then at his wife, and then at the man sitting in his front room with an instrument across his knee, and did not say anything at all for a moment.

Billiam tried to read his father's face and got nothing off it, because he was too shocked himself to be reading anybody.

Aeska managed rather better, and what he saw arrive on the professor's face, and be put away again inside about a second, was recognition.

Then Annie was up out of the chair.

"Oh, Benjamin, you're home. I didn't expect you. We didn't." She was crossing

the room. “Well, we obviously didn’t know when you’d be back. And it’s great. It’s great to see you back.”

She got both arms round him and held on. He put one hand flat between her shoulders, the way you steady a thing rather than the way you hold one, and took it off again after about two seconds, and for most of those two seconds he was looking over the top of her head at Aeska.

Billiam looked away. Aeska did not.

“Yes.” He was already looking past her. “Look, Billy. I didn’t realise you had a guest.”

“It wasn’t planned.” Billiam got up. “This is Aeska. He’s one of my new friends. He needed a place to stay, just for tonight.”

“One of your friends?”

“Yeah, friends might not be the word.” He heard how that had come out. “You know. I hang out with people. Right?”

“I assume you do.”

And he looked at Aeska and waited, with the whole room waiting behind him.

Aeska stood up. He has changed a good deal in two years, and he was betting on it.

“Hello. My name is Aeska.” He kept it easy and slightly dull. “I met Billy at one of the pubs I play at. We get along. Billy likes my songs, and he asked me to come and do a performance for him and his mother. So here I am.”

“Yes. Right.” Benjamin nodded slowly. “Well. Pleasure to have you in my home, Aeska.”

And he put his hand out.

Aeska did not take it. He bowed instead, from the waist, the way a man bows when he has decided to be from somewhere else, and left the hand hanging in the air between them.

The professor drew it back a little way, and did not lower it, and kept it pointed at him.

*What are you doing here?*⁶

Aeska finished the bow.

It’s a long story, and I don’t have time to explain it now. But know that I don’t mean your wife or your son any harm.

From the other side of the room Billiam watched his father hold out a hand for a handshake that was never going to happen, and keep holding it out, and stand there looking at Aeska for several seconds longer than two men look at

⁶**Message.** A spell that puts a few words directly into one person’s ear across a room, unheard by anybody else, with room for a short answer. It requires that the caster point at the person he is speaking to, which is why it is usually done with a hand already doing something else.

each other, and then let it drop.

“Oh, yes.” Annie had come back in with cups. “The gentleman here, Aeska, will be staying. And I believe Billy’s got some other friends, some of whom might be staying as well. Billy?”

“I thought Felix would stay. But he had to go somewhere, so I don’t think he’s coming back.”

“Right. Okay. Yes.”

And Benjamin walked straight past his wife into the back of the house.

“I won’t be staying long. I have some research stored here that I need to collect.”

Annie stopped with the cups in her hands.

“Well. You’re not staying?”

“No. Very busy,” Benjamin said, without turning round. “Very busy at the moment at the guild.”

“You’ve been away a while.” Billiam had got up. “What have you been doing? What’s going on?”

His father looked at him, and then at Aeska, and then back at him.

“It’s not really something I can get into in detail. You know how it is with the top levels of these organisations. They want everything kept secret. They want everything behind closed doors.”

“Right.” He let that sit for about as long as he could stand to. “Actually, there’s something I wanted to talk to you about. If you have some time.”

There was a pause of a length that everybody in the room noticed.

“Yes. Come with me. We’ll go out to the yard.”

* * *

“The really important thing -”

Harriet Spurnhold got four words into it, and then a shot came out of the dark and took her in the neck.

There was no warning of it at all. There was a woman talking, and then there was a noise going round and round the walls of a round stone room, and she was on her back in the steam and the four words were the last of it. Whatever the really important thing was, she had not said it. Felix was three feet away with the ledger in both hands and her blood across the front of him.

She was not dead. She was on her back on the wet stone making a sound that was not breathing, with a long burn laid across the side of her throat, and her

hands going up to it and not getting there.

“Calder, no! Don’t!”

Lark shouted it from the crate and it was already too late. Calder had worked out where the shot came from before anybody else and had gone straight at it, across the open floor towards the eastern tunnels, and by the time she got the words out he was round the corner and gone.

What was in the tunnel was not a man.

It was standing square on its haunches about fifteen feet in, roughly the size of a large dog and nothing like one: a lithe hound-shaped thing of metal and cord with a long conical head where a muzzle should be, and it made no noise at all, because they do not. Calder had seen a howl before, at a distance, on a leash, walking beside somebody who could afford it. He had never been within twenty feet of one and had certainly never had one look at him, and one long professional glance was enough to tell him that whatever this was, it was past the standard build. A wolf where he had expected a dog.

Behind it the tunnel was empty. Whatever had shot her, this had not.

For a second he did not do anything at all. He stood in the mouth of that tunnel and looked at it and it looked back at him, and nothing in him moved.

Then he panicked. He was already turning to run when he cast it, which is why it went the way it did. The light came up in his eyes first, red, and ran down the insides of his forearms. Then three small furious suns went off his hand and down the tunnel in three different directions, while his shoulders were going the other way. None of them hit anything. One of them burst on the wall and lit the whole passage for half a second, and the thing was not where the light said it was.

It came off its haunches after him and closed its jaws where his leg had been, with a snap like a press coming down. The hardened air took it. He heard metal grind on metal a hand’s width from his knee and kept going.

He got back into the round chamber and behind Felix.

Felix had not moved. He put a word and a gesture into Harriet from where he stood,⁷ and the grey sparks went into her throat and found the hole in it, and she came back with a jolt, still on her back, still full of blood, her eyes wide open and moving.

“Felix. Felix. What -” She got a hand round his wrist. “What is this?”

“We have to go, Harriet.”

“Just go. Just go, just go.”

He got her up under one arm with the ledger in the other and made it as far as the middle of the room, and that was when a man leaned out over the barricade.

⁷**Healing Word.** A healing spoken rather than laid on, which is why it can be done across a room. Quick, and shallow, and enough to put somebody back on their feet.

The man was up about ten feet, in the dark at the top of the eastern wall, and he had been there the whole time. Lark saw the carbine come over the lip of it, and saw him do something to the weapon before he put it on Felix, some adjustment that made it whine as it came up. She threw a hand out from the crate across forty feet of open floor. A plate of nothing formed in front of Felix, about the size of a dinner plate and entirely invisible until the shot arrived, and then it lit white and the shot went through it having lost most of what it was carrying.⁸

It still put Felix on one knee. The second shot went past all three of them and broke on the far wall.

Then the howl came out of the tunnel and made the whole room in one jump.

Lark had come down off the crate by then and was in front of Felix and Harriet with the quarterstaff already moving. She caught it out of the air across the front legs and put it down hard, and the noise it made hitting the floor was the noise a filing cabinet makes going downstairs. It was up again immediately. It bit her twice before she could get the staff back between them.

And up on the barricade the man put two fingers in his mouth and whistled, one short shrill note, and something answered it from the north-east tunnel by scraping down the wall on its way in.

* * *

Out on the back step, four feet of window boxes away from his mother's beans, Billiam's father closed the door behind them.

"Billy. What are you doing with him? Do you know who he is?"

"I know his name." He had not expected to start there. "But Dad, listen, I'm in trouble. I'm in big trouble and I need your help. You heard Theodore was assassinated, right?"

"I did, yes," his father said.

"Well, me and a few others, including Aeska, we were there when it happened. And it looks like someone's trying to cover it up, and us being there, by association, we're getting targeted. By people from the Porter's Guild, I think, and maybe others. And things are getting a bit out of hand. Some people came and tried to attack one of my friends tonight. We got out, but -"

"Who is this we?" his father said.

⁸**Protective field.** Not a spell either, and not spoken. Lark puts a disc of hardened nothing into the air between somebody and a thing that is about to hit them, at a distance, without moving from where she stands. It takes most of what arrives and then it is gone.

“Like I said. People who were there when Theo was murdered. We tried to help him. It was too late.”

“Okay. Listen to me.” His father had not raised his voice at any point and did not now. “Billy, listen. You can’t get involved in this. You need to forget you saw anything to do with it. You need to get rid of this Aeska, you need to not associate with him, and you need to get back to your life as normal, as though none of it happened.”

“I’d like to get out of it. But it’s following us. They’ve seen our faces.”

“Who has?” his father said. “Who’s seen your faces?”

“Those people. I don’t know who they are. That’s what we’re trying to figure out.” He heard his own voice going up and could not get it back down. “That’s why I need your help. I think we’re all in danger.”

“You are very much in danger.”

He said it flatly, as a fact he already had, and it stopped Billiam entirely.

“Look. You shouldn’t be involved. The reason you’re supposed to be working at that scrapyard is to stay out of trouble, to stay away from exactly this.” A pause. “Have you done anything to bring this about? Have you committed any crimes?”

“There were some guards. When Theo died. Guild of Engineers, the guardsmen.” He left out everything that happened after that, and his father did not ask for it. “They saw me standing over his body. I don’t know if they think I killed him, or if they’re covering it up and I’m just a loose end. My friends too. I haven’t done anything. I’m just associated with it.”

“These people you’re talking about are a dangerous thing to be associated with.” He turned round. “And this person you have brought into our home is Aeska Volan.”

“Yeah. I know his name.”

“House Volan.” His father let that sit for a second. “He was touted to be the head of the Guild of Engineers when Dr Tammerton passes on. He was kicked out. He’s a wanted man.”

“Wanted?” Billiam had not moved. “What do you mean, wanted?”

“His family would very much like to see him, I would not say killed necessarily, but at least removed from the equation. He is a thorn in the engineers’ side, and if you are already wrapped up in engineer business then this pulls you deeper into it.”

“Look. I’m not saying I fully trust him.” He had his back against the door frame. “But he’s helped us get away with our lives. It could have gone really badly for us tonight if he hadn’t been there. I can’t believe he’s some kind of criminal.”

“What do you think he’s helping you for?” His father did not say it unkindly, which was worse. “He will use you as bait when the time comes and hand you to

the Guild of Engineers as the culprits, and no doubt.” He stopped himself. “Look. I don’t want to speak harshly about the man. But associating with him is enough on its own to put you on the radar, and from what you’re telling me you are already on it.” A breath. “The best thing you can do is turn yourself in.”

Somewhere below them a door went, and a woman called something to somebody two balconies down, and neither of them said anything until it had finished.

“But I didn’t do anything.” Billiam said it slowly. “To who?”

“To the Guild of Engineers.”

“And tell them what? That I killed Theo?”

“No. You didn’t kill Theo. You tell them you were there, and you tell them the truth, and maybe you get a couple of years in prison.” He said the next part as though it were reasonable, because to him it was. “This is the best you can do. You are risking your life.”

“I’m not going to prison. I didn’t do anything.”

“Billy.” He took a step closer. “You know the situation in this city. You know the power of the guilds. They do not care whether you did it or not. They will remove you from the board one way or another.”

“Isn’t there something else we can do? You don’t actually want me to go to prison.”

“I don’t want you to die,” his father said. “That is what I don’t want.” A pause. “If prison for a few years is the solution to that, then that’s the solution we take. I have no sway inside the Guild of Engineers.”

“I can’t believe you’d say that to me.” Billiam’s voice had gone somewhere else. “You’d really tell me to just go to prison. For years.”

“It is the only choice.” And then, because his son had not answered: “Would you rather die?”

“I don’t believe that’s the only choice,” Billiam said. “There has to be something else.”

“You are messing with forces far beyond your control here. These people will not stop until they have dealt with you. And if they believe you have information about any plot, then let me tell you that the things they are working on are far too precious for them to allow anything to go wrong because somebody was in the wrong place at the wrong time.”

Billiam stood in his mother’s four feet of garden and looked at his father.

“How do you even know all this stuff?” he said. “Are you in with them? Are you part of the plot to assassinate the old man?”

“No. No. I would never be part of a plot to assassinate anybody.” That one came fast and it came clean. “But I have been working with the Guild of Engineers on a project, and so I know what they are like. I’ve worked with them on and off for

many years. It is not a place you want to get involved with.”

“Then why are you still involved with them, if they’re so horrible?”

And his father stopped.

It was not long. It was less than a second, a hitch on the front of a sentence he had clearly said before, and Billiam had been watching his face when it happened.

“Look. I wish I could explain more about what I’m doing.” He got moving again. “It’s important work. This is revolutionary. And I don’t particularly like the guild, but they are the only ones in a position to make this sort of thing actually happen. Better the Velar you know.” A gesture. “There are bad people all over this city, but that doesn’t mean progress can’t happen with them or without them, and as much as I am remiss to deal with the guild, I am forced to. If I did not do this, somebody else would, and they may not have the same moral compass I do.” He turned back. “I think I have raised you well enough to understand that we do what we can, when we can. We don’t go out on a limb and get ourselves killed for no good reason.”

“So what do we do now?” Billiam said. “Because Aeska’s in there. I don’t want to tell him to go away. Can’t you -”

“You need to tell him to go.”

“Can’t you do it?” Billiam said.

“Billy, you’re a grown man.”

“Well. Barely.”

“I can’t be solving your problems for you. Not with the situation you are in now.” He said it patiently, the way you explain something for the second time. “You need to take charge here. You need to take responsibility. You need to walk in there and tell him you will not be associating with him any more, that you know who he is and you know what he is planning, and that you are going to turn yourself in.” He paused. “And perhaps, if you give them what you know about Aeska, they may be more lenient with you. Perhaps you know where he sleeps. You could give them something towards his arrest. Perhaps you could get off with hard labour for a few months.”

“If I do turn myself in.” Billiam had been quiet long enough that his father had started to say something else, and stopped. He was looking at the beans. “Could you at least help me get a decent room? If I go to prison.”

“Look. I’ll see what I can do. I don’t have sway over the guild.” A short laugh with nothing in it. “If it were the College imprisoning you, of course, you would live a life of luxury.”

“But what if I go to prison,” Billiam said, “and another accident happens?”

“What do you mean, another accident?”

“You know.” He did not look up. “Like the floor. In our house.”

“Well. They.” His father turned the watering can round with his foot, which was the first thing either of them had touched out there. “And I suppose I shouldn’t really mention this.” He said the rest of it carefully, in a lower register. “But there are some people within the Guild of Engineers who can remove your ability.”

“They can?”

“Likely, if you were causing an issue, they would look at that as a means of correcting the problem.” He put his hand out and did not quite put it on his son. “But you know how I feel about that. It is not something I want for you.”

“It’d make my life a lot easier,” Billiam said.

“You haven’t had any major problems for a while, if I’m correct.” A pause. “I know I haven’t been around, and I apologise, but -”

“I have to live on my toes everywhere I go.” He got it out in one. “I barely have a job because of what might happen if I lose control of it.”

“There are people who would kill for the kind of power you have, Billy.” His father’s voice had changed. “You have to understand it isn’t just a curse. It is a gift. A gift that is dangerous, certainly, but used the right way.” He was gathering himself back up as he spoke. “You just need time, and a place. Maybe prison would even be good for you. Though you run the risk, of course, and I don’t know how permanent those procedures are, and that is not something I would wish to happen.” He stopped, and started again more simply. “Look. I can’t tell you what to do. The only solution I have for you is to give yourself up. It is a harsh punishment for something you didn’t do, and it’s the only thing I can suggest. Unless you find a way to clear your name. Proof of some kind.” He shook his head. “But I don’t think they even believe you to be a murderer. I think they believe you to be a difficulty to remove. And whatever else you decide, get rid of your association with this Volan. Even if you solve your problem with the guild, the problem House Volan makes for you is just as bad.”

Billiam looked at his father for a long moment.

“I mean. Dad. I trust you.” He said it quietly. “If you think that’s what’s best, I’ll do it. I’ll send him home right now. Wherever home is for him.”

“It’s the only way we can keep you safe, Billy.”

“Okay.”

* * *

The second howl came into the chamber at speed and stopped at the far edge of

it, out of reach for the moment and not out of reach for long, and Calder did not run.

“Calder.” Lark had the staff up and the first one circling her. “Go. Just go, go, go.”

“We cannot outrun dogs.”

Calder stayed where he was. That left him ten feet behind Lark, with Lark between himself and the howl, and he did not appear to have noticed that this was the arrangement he had chosen. Instead of moving he put his hand out at the barricade and threw three more orbs up through the steam at the man on it. One of them found him. They heard him swear and drop down behind the stone.

Felix, from the mouth of the western tunnel with Harriet already past him, threw something else at the same place: not fire but a thin grey spray, like poison out of a bottle, that went up over the lip of the barricade and caught him.⁹

“Calder!” Felix again. “We need to go.”

Calder did not move.

And Lark stopped, in the middle of all of it, and looked round the room, and counted.

Two of them in here with her, and the second one untouched. A man on the wall above with a rifle he could overcharge. Felix at the mouth of the western tunnel with a book he was not going to put down and a hole in his leg. Harriet somewhere behind him in the dark, unarmed, barely upright, bleeding through her own neck. And Calder, ten feet away, out in the open, refusing to move.

Every one of them was going to die in this room, and nobody was coming to stop it.

That was what did it. It came up out of her without her asking for it. Her eyes lit first and then the freckles across her nose and cheeks, a hard clean white, and her hair lifted off her shoulders, and the air around her went over into something that hurt to stand near.¹⁰ Ten feet away Calder felt his face begin to sting and understood, too late to do anything about it, that he had chosen the wrong place to make his stand.

She hit the first howl and put it flat on the stone again and stood over it burning.

On the barricade the man made his decision. He was hurt, and he was poisoned, and he was in the best possible position from which to leave, and the two

⁹**Ray of Sickness.** A spell thrown as a spray of grey, which does its damage and then leaves the person it hit poisoned for a while afterwards. Nothing about it is elegant. It is a spell for making somebody worse at their job.

¹⁰**Inner radiance.** Not a spell and not learned. Something in Lark rises under pressure and burns outward from her in a steady pulse, for as long as it lasts, and it makes no distinction whatever between the people trying to kill her and the people standing behind her.

things in the room were not his to lose in any way that mattered. He went back over the wall and down the eastern tunnel at a run, and did not whistle either of them after him.

Both howls stayed.

The one on the ground got its legs under it and did not go for Lark at all. It came off the floor in one long jump the whole width of the chamber and landed on Felix, and got its jaws round the back of his ankle and started to pull, and the second one crossed the room and took Calder off his feet.

“Can you two handle this?” Calder had it off him and was already looking down the eastern tunnel.

“Calder, we need to go!”

“I’ll take that as a yes.”

He went somewhere else. It is his one useful trick for exactly this, a step that is not a step. He was there, and then the air folded and he was thirty feet along the eastern tunnel with no ground crossed in between,¹¹ and he threw fire down it after the shooter and hit the wall, and watched the man run out through the far edge of what he could see and be gone.

Behind him the room got worse.

Felix put lightning through the thing at his ankle and missed it entirely, and got a word of healing into himself instead. Lark came off her own howl, went round the outside, and killed the one on Felix: she took its legs, put it down, brought the staff through the middle of it, and the burn coming out of her did the last of it while it lay there. It stopped moving and did not start again.

Which left one, and it was the fresh one, and it went for her.

It hit her twice, high on the chest, and she came off her feet and did not get up. Her staff stayed in her hand. The light stayed on. Whatever it was that had come up out of her, it did not go out when she did, and it went on pulsing off her while she lay on her back on the stone with a construct standing over her.

Calder came back down the tunnel at a run and stopped at the mouth of it.

One howl was dead. The other was standing on Lark, who was not moving, and still burning. Felix was on his feet and had very little left in him.

Calder put fire into the thing from where he stood and it took it badly. Felix came in behind that and got a hand flat on the housing and put lightning through it, and the shock went in far harder than anything that size had any business being hurt by, and the plates along its back lifted.

Then Felix spent almost the last of what he had on a word thrown across the floor at Lark. It was barely anything. She came back on one breath, with nothing

¹¹**Misty Step.** A short jump made without going through the space between. The caster must be able to see where he is going, and he arrives all at once.

to spare at all, and got up anyway.

Lark got up in a way none of them had seen before, putting a hand flat on the stone and throwing her whole body over and past the thing to come up behind it.

But the howl was not interested in her any more. It had worked out which of them was carrying the ledger.

It came off her and went at Felix and hit him twice, and he went down under it, and this time he stayed down. Then the howl put its head down, took the ledger out of his hands in its jaws, turned, and ran for the tunnel.

Calder folded the air a second time and came out standing on the steam vent in the middle of the room with the column going up all round him, and then off it and after the thing, and put a ray of cold down the tunnel that caught it across the back legs.¹² It did not stop. It slowed.

That was enough for Lark, who had already started running.

She went sixty feet down that tunnel flat out with nothing left in her, and caught it, and killed it, and stood over it in the dark with the last of the light going out of her while the ledger lay on the stones under its jaw.

Back in the chamber, Calder got to Felix and turned him over. Felix was dying, and was a good deal closer to it than anybody in that room understood at the time. Calder knelt down in it and got the bleeding stopped, and got him breathing.

Harriet came back along the western tunnel and stopped at the edge of the room, looking at the three of them and two broken constructs and the steam going peacefully up out of the middle of it.

"I don't know if any more of them will come." Her voice was ruined. "We need to go. We need to go right now."

Lark came back with the ledger under one arm and put a healing into Felix with the other hand, and he came round and got his feet under him, and the four of them went out down the western tunnel with the book.

* * *

Up in the Stacks, on a step four feet from his mother's window boxes, Billiam turned round and went back inside to do the thing he had agreed to do.

Annie was in the front room laying out blankets on the floor and being cheerful about the arrangements.

¹²**Ray of Frost.** A line of cold thrown from the hand. It hurts, and more usefully it slows whatever it hits, which is often the point.

The chair by the wall was empty. The instrument was not on the back of it. The cup Billiam had poured an hour ago was still standing on the table where he had put it down, and it was still full, and it had gone cold.

Aeska had gone.